

Mac machines. So, when we wanted people to move on from Windows, they agreed to; but instead of moving to Linux, they chose the Mac. We now have a limited number of people using Linux, and all of them are engineers. But at the data centre level, CentOS is winning the game.

Q When you deployed open source technology at the data centre level, did you face some resistance from within the company, because quite a few open source projects are still based on a vibrant community, rather than official support?

In our case, the advantage is that 100 per cent of our application development happens in-house. So, we are not so dependent on any external developer. When we started moving to the open source model, there were multiple challenges, which when we overcame and scaled up, we realised were really the advantages of moving to Linux. Initially, the discussions were around points like how to remember so many commands, when we move from a beautiful looking GUI. In Windows, one doesn't have to remember things. Individuals just need to navigate and figure things out. Initially, that was a hurdle, definitely; but as we started deploying more servers, we realised that having commands, having them scripted and then moving to an automation tool or a configuration management tool, actually makes it super easy to deploy divisions of servers at the same time. On the other hand, with Windows, one is stuck and automation scripts are not easy to run. Even if you make an automation script, you still have to remotely access the servers and run it. Running scripts from remote desktops is not well supported by Windows. All these things, which were earlier the benefits of the Windows GUI, became its drawbacks.

With Linux, the scale comes in. Earlier, we used to deploy one server in a few months, but now we can run many servers in a day. So, speed and automation is very important. Without that, we cannot deploy so many servers. Thus, earlier, something that was a drawback—having a console or shell access—later became an advantage. And most people like me converted and adopted Linux. I was a hardcore Windows guy, till I tasted Linux.

Q What was the turning point that led to your conversion?

The feeling of having complete control helped to change my mind. The number of things that you can do and customise Linux for is amazing. With Windows, one has to often say, "It is not possible." For instance, security is very important for any e-commerce player and there is no control over security in Windows. But when it comes to Linux, you have a lot of control. In case you are on Windows, you have no choice but to believe that the team sitting in Redmond is doing a good job. In the case of Linux, even if there is a vulnerability, you can download the source code and fix it. Although, as a company, one wouldn't want to do that, but if the need arose, one can. Earlier, we never compiled packages for customisation. But recently we have started doing that. That's the kind of power we got with Linux and it has added so

much to our performance that we now don't have an option.

Q Tell us more about your company's open source journey and when did you think you would make it a career choice?

In 2009, open source was recommended to me by most of my peers in the industry. People used to ask, "Why asp.net?" and our only answer was, "Because this is what our engineers know." Eventually, we decided to go with the LAMP stack, and since then, we've actually never faced any issues. Scaling, initially, was a big problem, but just by moving from one platform to the other, we found that scaling became much easier. Our internal research shows that there is a 3X difference in resource utilisation when moving from Windows to Linux.

In Linux, the more you optimise, the better the performance. That was the one thing that made us start our journey with Linux. Our engineering team, at that time, had absolutely no knowledge of Linux. We had to learn all of it and that was a huge initial effort, which required a very big reason for us to go ahead. And that reason was performance.

Once we started learning it, we found that control was another reason that kept us going. The third phase involved automation with tools like Puppet, which helped us decide that this is the way to go. At the same time, the variety of programming languages as well as the options in databases attracted us a lot.

Q When you proposed open source technology to your board, were there any inhibitions?

No. In fact, our company is very cool in that way. Our founders give us the freedom to do whatever we want. As long as there are no hurdles and the business is progressing well, they don't have any issues. As a tech team, we have to just make sure that whatever decisions we take, do not backfire on the business. This kind of freedom helps us experiment with tech stuff. We experiment a lot with newer technologies and adopt them very fast.

Q Do you or any of your team mates contribute to open source technologies?

Not yet. We are still catching up with our business requirements.

Q What are the new areas where you see yourself exploring open source technologies for your business?

There are a lot of things in Big Data that involve open source technologies, which are not enterprise-friendly. However, there are companies that are making open source technologies enterprise-friendly. They are branding their solutions and making them easy to use. This is good, but I think what we are missing is the packaging of open source software from the community. This is something that needs to be improved upon. The packaging needs to be done well to make it more enterprise-friendly. 